SCNC3111 Frontiers of Science Honours Seminar Course
Project Guideline

Your Task

For this Group Project, you will work in a group of **two to three** students to give a 15-minute (subject to confirmation after the add/drop period) oral presentation on a research topic of your choice, followed by a 10-minute Q&A. The main focus of this project should be "How your chosen research topic has evolved over the past decades?" It is suggested that research articles from two different time periods (e.g. now vs 50 years ago) should be selected for comparison. The main aim of this project is for you to elaborate on the current frontier of your chosen area and how the current status was evolved from the previous paradigm.

To make sure a proper topic is chosen on time, each group will have to submit a project plan before 11:30 a.m., October 20, 2026. In this project plan, each group will indicate:

1. the main topic to be investigated in the presentation;
2. research articles on this topic from at least two different time periods (these periods should be sufficiently far away from one another to demonstrate how our understanding on the project topic has been evolving);
3. some brief findings from comparing these research articles.

The Project Plan should be 1-page long, including your references. You will have to be succinct in your plan and be selective in listing the more important research articles! **Please also note that late submission will not be graded.**

To submit your Project Plan, you must put your university numbers, and the subject area of your research, separated by the underscore (_), into the file name of your Project Plan. The subject area must be chosen from one of the following five: Biology, Chemistry, Earth and Planetary Sciences, Mathematics_Statistics, and Physics. If your research is inter-disciplinary, please choose the subject area closest to your project.

If, for example, your university numbers are 3035123456, 3035654321, and your chosen subject is Earth Sciences, then the file name of your Project Plan must be 3035123456_3035654321_EarthAndPlanetarySciences.pdf. You must also enter your file name (e.g.3035123456_3035654321_EarthAndPlanetarySciences) as the "Submission Title" when submitting the Project Plan via this link. Marks will be deducted if you do not follow this rule. Only one representative from each group will need to submit the Project Plan on behalf of the whole group.

The oral presentation will be given during our class on November 10, 13, 17, 20, 24 (optional), 2026. You will be informed of the presentation schedule in due course. All groups will have to submit their presentation file by 11:30 a.m., November 10, 2026. Five (out of 30) marks will be deducted from each student if your group fails to submit the file before the deadline.

Assessment

This Group Project contributes to 30% of your final course grade with the following breakdown:

1. Project Plan - 5%;
2. Assessment of your presentation by your fellow classmates - 10%;
3. Assessment of your presentation by the SCNC3111 Teaching Team – 15%.

Both students in the same group will receive the same score unless there is a free-rider issue. You may indicate the workload distribution in the file.

All the group members will present in a reasonably fair amount of time. The group member who presents in a significant less amount of time will be considered as a free rider.

The number of students in each group must be 2 or 3. No marks will be given to any group with 1 student or more than 3 students.

In case your group wants to change the project topic, please make sure that you write to the course coordinator and get an approval. Your project will not be assessed if your project plan is not approved.

Marking Rubric for Project Plan:

Excellent (4-5)	Average (2-3)	Poor (0-1)
The plan satisfies all or almost all of the following criteria: 1. the indication of relevant, well-chosen research articles; 2. clear explanation of the topic with strong connection to the cited research articles; 3. the indication of potentially rich comparison which can be made from the cited research articles.	The plan showed some of the following issues: 1. unclear explanation; 2. weak connection between the topic and the cited research articles; 3. failure to describe potentially rich comparison which can be made from the cited research articles.	The plan showed a lot of the following issues: 1. unclear explanation; 2. weak connection between the topic and the cited research articles; 3. failure to describe potentially rich comparison which can be made from the cited research articles.

Marking Rubrics

Your Group Project will be graded according to the following marking rubrics:

Marking Rubric for Presentation (by both your fellow classmates and the SCNC3111 Teaching Team):

	Excellent (4-5)	Average (2-3)	Poor (0-1)
Quality of research and analysis	Consistently demonstrated an excellent understanding of the topic and well researched preparation. Excellent analysis of the chosen topic and comparison.	Mostly demonstrated a good understanding of the topic and some research in preparation. Some items were omitted that would have enhanced the analysis.	Little evidence of understanding the topic and lack of research preparation. Content was insufficient or inappropriate for analysis and comparison.
Clarity of presentation	Excellent organization of materials and logical flow. The speaker used good tone and expression and made good eye contact. Consistently engaging the audience.	Reasonable evidence of organization of materials and mostly logical flow. Used good tone and expression most of the time. The presentation was moderately engaging, but sometimes lost audience's attentiveness.	Not well organized. Did not flow logically from idea to idea. Poor control of voice and expression. Did not engage, or attempt to engage the audience through any type of interactivity.
Question and answer	Excellent handling of questions that were well addressed. Stated relevant and justifiable answers. Presented arguments in a logical order.	Did not address the question(s) explicitly. Stated some relevant and justifiable answers. Presented arguments mostly in a logical order.	Did not address the question(s). Stated no relevant answers and indicated misconceptions. Arguments were not clearly or logically organized.

All three criteria in this rubric carry the same weighting.